

Cause and Effect - Study Guide

Explain why something happens and what follows - without mistaking timing or coincidence for cause.

Learning goal

Identify explicit and implied causal relationships, separate causes from effects and contributing conditions, and recognize when the text supports only a correlation.

Cause and effect is a relationship, not just an order

A cause helps produce an outcome. An effect is the result. Texts sometimes state this directly with words such as because, therefore, as a result, led to, or due to. Harder questions may leave the relationship unstated and require you to connect several details.

Two events can happen close together without one causing the other. If a passage says attendance rose during the same month that a new bus stop opened, that is not enough by itself to prove the bus stop caused the increase.

Relationship	What it means	Example
Cause	The factor that helps produce the result	Shade lowers the amount of sunlight reaching the pavement.
Effect	What happens as a result	The shaded pavement stays cooler.
Contributing condition	One factor among several	Cooler weather may also reduce pavement temperature.
Correlation	Two things change together, but the text does not prove why	Attendance rose while a new bus stop opened.

Question language to recognize

- According to the passage, what causes ____?
- Which detail best explains why ____ happened?

- What is one likely effect of ____?
- Which conclusion about the reason for ____ is best supported?

A reliable method

- 1 Name the outcome in the question.
- 2 Find the factor the text connects to that outcome. Look for a mechanism, not just something that happened earlier.
- 3 Check direction: could you write CAUSE -> EFFECT without reversing them?
- 4 If the text mentions another possible factor, choose a cautious answer that does not claim more certainty than the evidence supports.

The because test

Try the sentence: EFFECT happened because CAUSE. If that sentence reverses the passage or requires new assumptions, reject the option.

Worked example

Example

A school painted half of a rooftop with a reflective coating and left the other half unchanged. During sunny afternoons, sensors above the coated section recorded lower surface temperatures. Both sections received the same amount of shade. Researchers concluded that the coating reduced heat absorption on those afternoons.

1. Which factor does the passage identify as the cause of the lower surface temperatures?

- A. The reflective coating
- B. Extra shade
- C. Lower morning temperatures
- D. Fewer sensors

Answer: A

The design holds shade constant and connects the coating to reduced heat absorption. The lower temperature is the effect, not the cause.

Common traps

- Choosing an event that happened first but is not connected as a cause.
- Reversing the relationship by selecting the effect as the cause.
- Treating one coincidence as proof of causation.
- Ignoring a confounding factor the passage explicitly says may also matter.

Quick check

Mini text

A clinic shortened its online appointment form from twelve fields to seven. The following month, the percentage of users who finished the form increased. During that month, the clinic also began offering a free phone-help service for users who had trouble online.

1. Which conclusion is most careful?

- A. The shorter form definitely caused the entire increase.
- B. The phone service definitely caused the entire increase.
- C. The shorter form may have helped, but the phone service could also have affected completion.
- D. Neither change could have affected completion.

Answer: C. The passage includes two changes that could influence the result.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1

If: You assume that because two events happened together, one must have caused the other.

Try: Look for a stated or strongly supported mechanism. If another factor could explain the result, keep the claim cautious.

2

If: You reverse the relationship.

Try: Say it aloud as X led to Y. Then check whether the passage actually supports that direction.

3

If: You turn one contributing factor into the only cause.

Try: Watch for language such as partly, also, may, and contributed. Preserve the author's level of certainty.

30-second reset

Before the next cause & effect question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.